VIENNA, AUSTRIA

Belvedere: Masterpieces

Embraces, portraits and still lifes reveal how closely a figure can belong to its setting—or resist it.



Schiele's embracing bodies press into a creased sheet whose folds are scarcely calmer than their limbs. Klimt's lovers, by contrast, nearly disappear into the joined decoration of their clothes. In both pictures contact is central, but the surrounding surface makes that contact feel and look different.

The comparison extends beyond couples. A fan can balance a portrait's elaborate dress; a doorway can separate a woman from the room behind her; a slaughtered animal can disturb an otherwise recognisable still life. This selection considers how figures and objects occupy their painted ground. The familiar works reward attention alongside quieter pictures, where the same problem may be easier to isolate.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/belvedere

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20. Squatting Couple, The Family
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The Embrace

Egon Schiele

1917 · Belvedere



Egon Schiele. The embrace. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sheet does not soften the intertwined bodies into an easy resting shape. Its creases repeat and extend their angular contours, carrying the pressure of contact beyond the skin. Schiele encloses the couple within a compact arrangement against the yellow surroundings. The embrace is made visible as a relationship of bent limbs, weight and shared surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4438

02 / 20

On the Balcony

Anton Romako

1878 · Oil on wood · Belvedere



On the Balcony. WikiArt; WikiArt. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Public domain

The woman's back keeps her attention outside while the viewer remains within the room. Her pale blue dress occupies a narrow doorway between those positions. Roofs and street are available beyond the railing, but the confined opening matters as much as the prospect. Romako makes looking out a particular bodily situation rather than simply another landscape view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1424

03 / 20

At the Wolfgangsee

Anton Romako

1877 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Anton Romako. At the Wolfgangsee. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/anton-romako/evening-in-the-prossau-near-gastein-1877 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Low boats and a tall wayside cross establish different directions near the water. Their practical and devotional functions share a foreground before the mountains. Romako does not need to isolate the religious marker in order to give it a presence. Its vertical form distinguishes it within a lakeside environment also organised around transport and shelter.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Babette Tapecierer

Anton Romako

c.1873 - c. 1876 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Anton Romako. Babette Tapecierer. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/anton-romako/babette-tapecierer-1876 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The open fan supplies a broad pale shape below the busy neckline. Lace, bow and blue clothing frame the face against warm red, giving Romako several kinds of surface to balance. The sitter remains directly identifiable within that elaboration. Following the fan back toward the face makes the portrait's organisation clearer than treating the costume as detachable ornament.

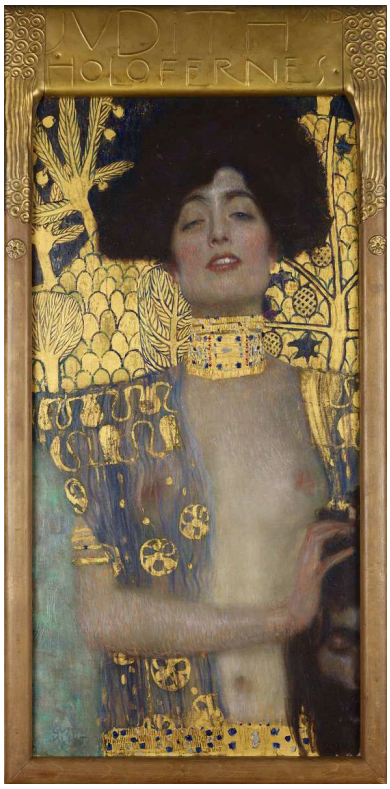
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Judith

Gustav Klimt

1901 · Oil and gold leaf on canvas · Belvedere



Gustav Klimt. Judith and the Head of Holofernes. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/gustav-klimt/judith-and-holopherne-1901 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Holofernes's severed head is partly withheld at the lower edge. Jewellery, skin and gold take visual precedence, so recognising the biblical aftermath can lag behind noticing the portrait-like figure. Klimt makes that imbalance consequential. Judith's presentation occupies most of the image, while the evidence of her violent action enters through a margin rather than through a fully staged narrative.

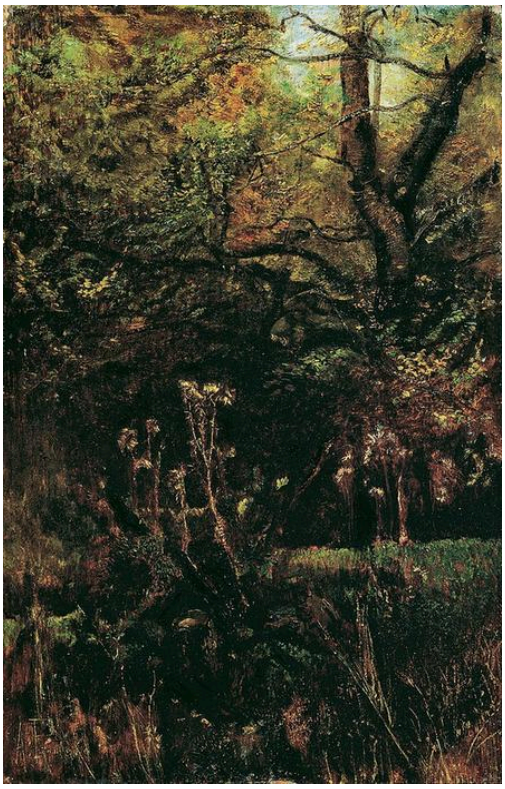
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4737

06 / 20

Forest Clearing with Thistles

Anton Romako

1885 · Oil on panel · Belvedere



Anton Romako. Forest clearing with thistles. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/anton-romako/forest-clearing-with-thistles-1885 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Thistles claim the near space that a landscape might reserve for a figure or path. Branches and overlapping growth provide depth without an easy route inward. Small openings of light do not fully clear the density. Romako gives a plant that might be passed over in a broader prospect enough prominence to organise the view.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

The Kiss

Gustav Klimt

c. 1907–1909 · Gold, silver and platinum leaf; resin-oil colours on primed canvas; composition gold (brass), glazes and metal-leaf flakes in background · Belvedere



Gustav Klimt. The Kiss (Lovers). Image credit: Joseolgon; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Interior_of_Belvedere_Palace_(8).jpg. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 4.0

Pattern nearly joins the garments into one enclosure, while exposed hands and faces preserve the particular actions of the two bodies. Bare feet and the flowered bank locate their contact at the lower edge. Klimt moves between bodily recognition and ornament. The embrace remains legible because a few unpatterned areas carry more descriptive weight than the expansive gold around them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 912

08 / 20

Girl Picking Apples

Anton Romako

c. 1882 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Girl Picking Apples. WikiArt; WikiArt. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Public domain

The upward reach is determined by the tree rather than by a formal portrait pose. A held branch and the extended arms connect the girl's body directly to the surrounding apples and leaves. Romako lets a small task generate the composition. The figure's relationship to the setting is practical before it becomes decorative.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1280

09 / 20

Still Life with a Slaughtered Lamb

Oskar Kokoschka

1910 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Oskar Kokoschka. Still life with a slaughtered lamb. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/oskar-kokoschka/still-life-with-a-slaughtered-lamb · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Flowers and a vessel belong to a familiar tabletop arrangement; the dead lamb changes its register. Kokoschka does not isolate the body from the other objects, and uneven marks keep the entire surface disturbed. The painting asks the still life's descriptive attention to accommodate something difficult. Material presence does not become neutral simply because its subject is motionless.

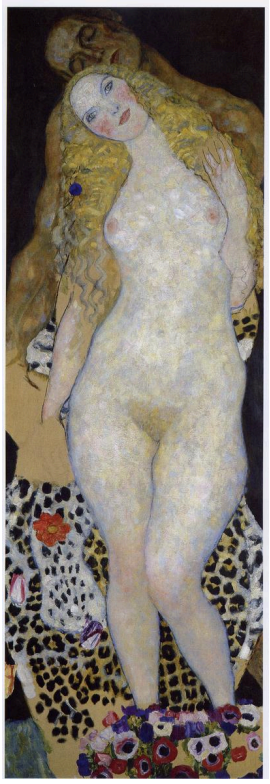
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Adam and Eve

Gustav Klimt

1917–1918 · Oil on canvas (unfinished) · Belvedere



Gustav Klimt. Adam and Eve. Image credit: Gustav Klimt; Originally from it.wikipedia ; description page is/was here . Original uploader was Melancholyblues. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Adam_and_Eve_Gustav_Klimt.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The pale standing woman takes most of the available visibility, with the darker man partly behind. Pattern gathers below their bodies instead of surrounding them equally. Klimt distributes exposure unevenly within the pair. Compared with the merged garments of *The Kiss*, this arrangement separates the figures more strongly through their different relations to light and surface.

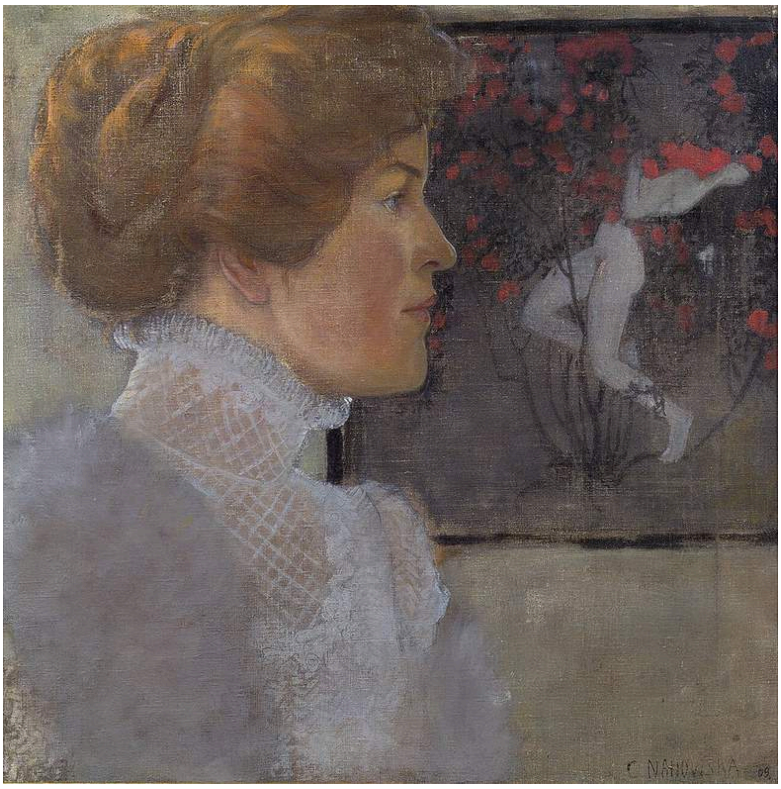
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4402

11 / 20

Portrait of a Woman

Carola Nahowska

1909 · Belvedere



Carola Nahowska · Belvedere · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons · Public domain

The high pale collar lifts the profile clear of the darker room. A picture on the wall introduces another represented figure nearby, placing the sitter within an environment already containing images. Nahowska's close framing preserves only part of that interior. The portrait feels located among things rather than given an empty ground solely for its likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 9745

12 / 20

Early Spring in the Vienna Woods

Ferdinand Georg Waldmüller

1861 · Oil on wood · Belvedere



Ferdinand Georg Waldmüller. Early Spring in the Vienna Woods. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Bare branches remain above patches of new green, allowing the season to appear as a mixture of conditions. Children gather on a woodland slope whose close, steep terrain gives their activity a particular footing. Waldmüller links spring to this uneven piece of ground. The familiar subject gains specificity from where bodies must stand and move.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1501

13 / 20

Madame Legois

Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot

c. 1840–1845 · Belvedere



Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot. Madame Legois. Image credit: Jean-Baptiste Camille Corot; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Corot_Madame_Legois.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Red above a white skirt creates a compact division of the seated figure. Joined resting hands and an upright posture remain clear against the muted setting. Corot limits the number of strong shapes, giving each a substantial role in the likeness. The encounter depends on a held bodily arrangement rather than an abundance of personal accessories.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2413

14 / 20

Napoleon at the Great Saint Bernard Pass

Jacques-Louis David

1801 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Jacques-Louis David. Napoleon at the Great St. Bernard Pass. Image credit: Jacques-Louis David; Own work David Monniaux. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Napoleon_by_David_DSC03022.JPG. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 3.0

Horse, cloak, pointing arm and steep ground carry movement along related diagonals. David makes the landscape collaborate in a public image of command. The rearing animal supplies force that the rider appears able to direct. This is an organised representation of authority; treating it as an incidental record of crossing a pass would miss its central construction.

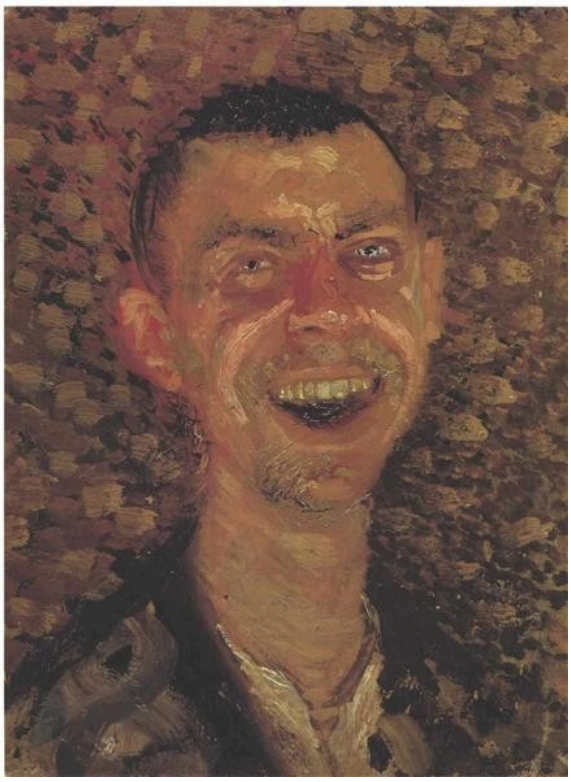
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2089

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Self-Portrait, Laughing

Richard Gerstl

1908 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Richard Gerstl. Self-Portrait, Laughing. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Bright teeth and an open mouth interrupt the face's roughly worked colour. The surrounding paint continues that activity rather than providing a quiet border around the expression. Gerstl replaces the composed presentation expected of a formal self-portrait with something less settled. The picture shows a deliberately visible expression without giving certain access to the painter's underlying state of mind.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4035

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Sonja Knips

Gustav Klimt

1897/1898 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Gustav Klimt. Sonja Knips. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The dress spreads widely, but the upper body holds a poised position near the chair's edge. A small red book interrupts the pale pink fabric. Klimt balances expansiveness with a few concentrated signs of attention, keeping the sitter from being absorbed by the costume. The forward placement gives the soft surrounding forms a more alert centre.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4403

17 / 20

Still Life with Chrysanthemums and Amaryllis

Lovis Corinth

1922 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Lovis Corinth. Still Life with Chrysanthemums and Amaryllis. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Petals remain recognisable while streaks of colour pass into the surrounding surface. Corinth lets a crowded bouquet become an accumulation of marks as well as a group of flowers. The two readings support one another: floral density gives the handling a subject, and the handling prevents that subject from becoming a neat inventory of separate blooms.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2446

18 / 20

Still Life with Five Bottles

Vincent van Gogh

1884 · Belvedere



Vincent van Gogh. Still Life with Five Bottles. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Restricted greens and browns make variations in height and silhouette especially useful. Upright bottles stand close while a horizontal vessel interrupts their bases. Van Gogh's small group asks attention to measured differences of reflection and shape. With no narrative event to organise the scene, the placement of one container against another carries the picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 7762

19 / 20

The Chef, Le Père Paul

Claude Monet

1882 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



Claude Monet. The Chef (Le Père Paul). Image credit: Kadı; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Claude_Monet%27s_painting.jpg. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC0

The white cap identifies an occupation while the close framing directs attention toward the bearded face. Monet keeps the setting subdued enough for both to remain clear. Work clothes are neither removed for ceremony nor allowed to replace the individual likeness. The portrait gives a working person a concentrated presence without surrounding him with a scene of labour.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 540

20 / 20

Squatting Couple, The Family

Egon Schiele

1918 · Oil on canvas · Belvedere



The Family. WikiArt; Egon Schiele. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The crouching man, seated woman and low child build a triangular group through position. Their bodies touch the same compact field without sharing one repeated gesture. Schiele makes the family a visible arrangement among separate people. The title should not be allowed to turn that construction automatically into a documentary account of a particular domestic moment.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4277

Compare the surroundings of an embrace

Return to Schiele's creased sheet and Klimt's patterned gold. The bodies alone do not explain the difference between the images; the surfaces around them are part of the contact. These works are collection references rather than a fixed visiting route. Check the Belvedere's current display information, especially when planning around an individual painting.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky’s short book argues that colour and form can carry meaning beyond the objects they describe. It offers a contemporary point of comparison for Klimt, Gerstl and Schiele, whose methods differ considerably.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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